

« Most of our cricket was played in the streets, trying to emulate the greats that we had been reading about in books »

ROLAND BUTCHER

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Forty-four years after his historic Test debut as England's first black cricketer, Roland Orlando Butcher continues to observe hurdles hindering players from diverse backgrounds in the sport.

His entry into Test cricket in March 1981 not only celebrated his exceptional batting skills but also signalled to the fervent cricket community, particularly the West Indian diaspora in England, that reaching the pinnacle of the game was achievable.

In this chat with *Sportstar*, Butcher talks at length about his early days in the Caribbean, how he got hooked to cricket and the myriad challenges along the way.

Let's start with your childhood in Barbados. How did you get into cricket? Who were your heroes growing up? Where did you play?

I was born in East Point, St. Philip, Barbados, a very rural area close to the sea, right on the coast. As a kid, I got involved with cricket and fell in love with the sport at a very young age. By the time I was six, I was really hooked to the game. I played informally with the boys of my age and above, as there were no proper clubs nearby. Most of our cricket was played on the streets, trying to emulate the greats that we had been reading about in books. In those days, we didn't have television, so we had to read about the players in books or listen to the radio when

there was cricket going on. I remember lying in bed late at night, listening to the radio, when cricket was happening in Australia. I have a family connection to cricket as well; my family member, Basil Butcher, was a West Indies star player. His father originated from Barbados, but he was born in Guyana and played cricket for Guyana.

Do you recall the first game you watched live?

The first live cricket game I watched was in 1965, when the West Indies played Australia [in the second Test in Bridgetown]. My cousin, Monica Butcher, who has since passed away, took me to the game. It was a memorable match filled with runs. Bill Laurie and Bobby Simpson put on over 300 for the first wicket. Someone from the West Indies (Seymour Nurse) scored a double hundred, and somebody else (Rohan Kanhai) got a hundred. It was my first time watching a proper game of cricket and it really solidified my love for the sport. Growing up, I was

surrounded by females, as my father was in England. My grandmother and my aunt took care of me and my sister, while my other relatives were also mostly female. Despite the lack of male figures in the house, the women in the West Indies had a great love for cricket. It was unusual for a woman to take a boy to a cricket game, but I'm grateful that my cousin did. That experience meant a lot to me, and I'm thankful for it.

Your parents moved to England, and you joined them later. The weather and culture are vastly different. How challenging was this transition for you?

My parents had been in England since about 1955. I was born in 1953, and my mother joined my father a couple of years after that. I didn't actually come to England until 1967. It was very challenging. I arrived as a 13-year-old in May 1967, which should be the start of the summer, but for me, it was absolutely freezing. That was the first shock



It was through football that I got into cricket. On weekends, kids from the area would go to the local park, make makeshift goals, and play football for hours.